

the locals. Even though I hadn't been around long enough to learn which restaurants and bars were significantly cheaper, my local friends always knew the places to go. It's no good to just ask for recommendations, unfortunately. Most people will just point you toward the obvious tourist traps, especially if you don't speak the local lingo so well. I think a lot of them think that they're doing you a favor, making sure you can get a meal where someone speaks English.



It works in English-speaking countries, too. By hanging out with fellow college students on a trip to Oxford, I managed to get myself invited along to their version of the cafeteria on someone else's meal plan. Their food was much better than the typical American college's, too!

3. Order the soup

I was able to stretch my food budget in Ireland by ordering the soup, and I've

been able to use the same technique in a lot of places. As long as you enjoy chowders and stews, you're set! Most restaurants will add in bread, and I've never been hungry after a good-sized bowl of soup and some bread.

I try not to ask what's in soup anymore, though. I was in Doolin, Ireland (population 500), and in dire need of some lunch. The cheapest thing on the menu was seafood chowder. I ate a huge bowl, and it was delicious. Afterward, I made the mistake of asking the ingredients. The waitress gave me an odd look; turns out that scraps of just about every item on the menu made it into the chowder.

4. Greasy is okay

If you walk as much as I do when you're traveling, you'll burn the calories from that greasy kabob off the cart. I realize it's not the healthiest thing in the world, but it works for a quick, cheap meal. As long as you don't restrict your diet to greasy street food, you'll survive. And I think a lot of those barely identifiable meals on a stick can be pretty tasty. In Jerusalem, I always make a point of visiting the nearest falafel and shawarma stands. My money goes far, and I get what may be my favorite meal in the world.

— Thursday Bram